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Reading the newspapers these days, one would imagine we have regressed into the Dark Ages. Incidents of mob rule have risen alarmingly. Last week, a mob attacked a pregnant woman in Kerala on suspicion that she had stolen something, a man was lynched in Uttar Pradesh for the same reason while army recruits went berserk in Agra because a venue had been changed. Some weeks back, relatives of a patient who died burned down a hospital, lawyers beat up suspects in the court premises and kanwaris turned violent on the highway after one of their tribe was involved in a road accident. Students attacking schools and teachers, and political rallies turning violent is almost a given now. Mahatma Gandhi had pioneered the concept of peaceful civil disobedience but, had he been alive, he would have been shocked to see how it has become an excuse for wanton destruction. These are not politically-motivated hooligans who have infiltrated our system and are indulging in violence for political gain but ordinary citizens who now seem to have a very short fuse.

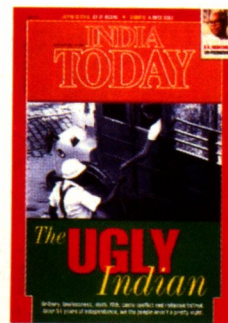
Our cover story examines the question why this is happening with such frequency. Our correspondents across the country deconstruct such instances to establish a pattern. Why did the incident happen, who were the people involved, the motivation, and what led them to react in an inhumane manner. We analyse the reasons why people fail to recognise the checks, balances and separation of responsibilities in a democracy. There are some obvious causes: the failure to provide employment which leads to millions of frustrated youth looking for an outlet; the failure of an overburdened judicial system where cases drag on for decades; bureaucratic lethargy to resolve issues speedily and the failure of the police to act in a sensitive manner or act at all. Also, there is no fear of the consequences.

All these, however, are not sufficient to explain the natural ease with which people transform into mobs and vent their anger. Indeed, the public display of anger is an indication of the suppressed violence in our society. By talking to a cross-section of people, victims and perpetrators of mob violence, judges, lawyers, sociologists, police officers, administrators and groups involved with civic issues to examine the cause and effect of today's mob rule, we have tried to establish whether India's social fabric can be mended to bring order to our streets.

Mobocracy is actually the antithesis of democracy and civil society. But its prevalence signifies that the ordinary citizen has lost faith in the system and he sees taking the law into his own hands as the only way out. This is dangerous and the onus is on the various authorities to restore the confidence of the people in them.

Aroon Purie

(Aroon Purie)



Our August 1998 cover